

Carry On, Mr. Bowditch

Chapter 4



CHAPTER 4



"BOYS DON'T BLUBBER"

A few days later Nat came out of school one afternoon and found Hab waiting for him. "Come on, Nat. I'm going to show you a new kind of ship. She's the *Freedom*."

Out on the wharf men were trundling boxes and bales of cargo to the *Freedom*.

"She isn't a privateer," Nat said. "She's carrying cargo." Then he saw guns mounted on the deck.

"She's a letter of marque ship," Hab said. "She carries cargo, but she can fight if she has to." Hab straightened. "I'm signed on her crew, Nat."

Nat gulped. "Does Mother know? And Father?"

“Sure, they all know. They understand. After all, I come from a long line of sea captains, don’t I? And I’m big for my age.”

“I’m growing,” Nat said. He grinned. “I bet next winter I’ll be too big for my coat, and William will get

it.” Nat remembered last winter when Hab had outgrown his coat. “Did you get cold last winter, Hab?”

“Plenty cold.”

Nat was puzzled. “But when the boys yelled at you, you always said, ‘I’m not cold. Only sissies need winter coats.’ ”

“Of course.” Hab frowned. “Boys don’t blubber. If something hurts, you say it doesn’t.” He looked up at the tall masts of the *Freedom* and grinned. “She’s a grand ship, isn’t she?”

Nat’s stomach felt hollow. What would it be like with Hab gone? But boys didn’t blubber. He bit his lips to steady them and squared his shoulders. “Yes, Hab. A grand ship. How — how — long before you sail?”

Hab shrugged and looked important. “We can’t tell. The British are trying to blockade the harbor. They’ve got ships offshore there, all the time, watching for our ships.”

“What — what — would happen if they’d catch the *Freedom?*”

Hab shrugged again. “They won’t.”

Nat shivered.

A few mornings later, when he awakened, Hab was gone. He’d left a note for Nat:

Dear Nat

It’s foggy tonight, so we’re going to sail. Tomorrow, the British will still be watching for us, but we’ll be gone. You’re the oldest boy now. Remember, boys don’t blubber.

Yours sincerely,

HAB

Nat scrambled into his clothes and hurried downstairs and out of the house. He ran toward the wharf. The *Freedom* was gone. Nat turned from the wharf, back into town, and climbed a little hill. He looked toward the sea. The fog had cleared. Had the *Freedom* escaped from the English ship? Or had she been captured? How long would it be before they'd know what happened? A year? Two years?

At the breakfast table, everyone talked fast, and tried to sound cheerful.

"I think the war's almost over," Father said. "That's what the shipowners think, too. You can tell. That's why they're sending out letter of marque ships now. If a privateer's at sea when the war ends, she'll have her voyage for nothing. But a letter of marque ship will go right on about her business, carrying cargo, buying and selling, making money for her owner . . . Making money hand over fist."

Nat knew Father was thinking about Elias Derby. He was one of the richest shipowners in Salem. People said he was one of the richest men in the country.

"If the war's almost over, will things get better now?" Lizza asked.

Father nodded. "Of course. Just any day now."

But things didn't get better. All summer prices climbed higher and higher and food got scarcer and scarcer. Sometimes Mother and Granny did not have anything to cook but potatoes, three meals a day.

In the fall, Hab came back. He was brown as an Indian. Granny said he had grown a foot in every direction.

"Did the *Freedom* have any fights?" Nat asked.

Hab shook his head and grinned. "Not a fight! The English can't catch her; she's too fast for them. Don't worry about the *Freedom*, Nat."

But a week later, when Hab sailed again, Nat did worry. Would the *Freedom* escape? How long before they'd know?

Then one morning Nat awakened suddenly to hear bells clanging and men shouting. Everybody in the house was stirring.

"I wonder what's wrong?" Mother said.

"It's a bad wreck, or a bad fire," Father said as he hurried to open the door.

Outside men were shouting, "Cornwallis is taken! We've won the war! Hoorraaaaay. Cornwallis is taken!"

For a moment everybody stood and stared; then they all began to laugh and talk at the same time. Father hugged Mother and Granny, Nat hugged Mary and Lizza, William and Sammy jumped up and down and yelled, even Lois, the baby, squealed.

After breakfast Nat and Lizza went with Father to watch the cheering, shouting crowds. When they neared Derby Wharf, they saw a tall, soldierly-looking man come out of one of the warehouses. The crowd cheered him.

Nat said, "Is he a general or something?"

“He’s Captain John Derby,” Father said. “Back in 1775, when the war started with the Battle of Lexington, the Americans wanted to get word to England just as fast as they could. They knew the King’s messenger would sail in the fastest ship he could find to tell the story of the battle the way the English soldiers wanted it told. The Americans wanted to reach England first with

their side of the story. The problem was to find a ship that was fast enough and a captain that was daring enough to reach England ahead of the English messenger. So, of course, they turned to Salem. They knew we had the finest ships and the best sailors in the country. Elias Derby’s ship, the *Quero*, carried the message. And Captain John Derby was the man that got the word to London.”

“Did he get there first — before the King’s messengers?” Lizza asked.

Father stared at her. “Lizza! What a question! Of course he got there first! Isn’t he a Salem man?”

Then Father grinned and Lizza giggled. She said, “Now things will get better, won’t they?”

“Of course they will!”

But prices went right on climbing; paper money was worth less and less. For a while it took ten paper dollars to equal one silver dollar, then twenty, then forty. Finally one hundred paper dollars would not buy a dollar’s worth of food. And prices were still climbing. Corn, that used to cost a few shillings a bushel, cost twenty-five dollars a bushel — in silver. In paper money, two thousand dollars would not buy a bushel of corn.

When winter came, Nat had outgrown his coat. He remembered what Hab had told him, and sometimes, when the boys jeered at him, he said, "I'm not cold. Only sissies need winter coats." Sometimes he just shrugged and didn't say anything. He was afraid if he tried to talk his teeth would chatter. Over and over he told himself, Boys don't blubber; that's the main thing. He thought of what people had said. When the war was

over, times would get better. Why didn't they? He asked Father about it.

"When peace comes," Father said, "things will get better."

"But the war's over, isn't it? Hasn't peace come?"

Father said, "The fighting has stopped, but they haven't settled the peace terms yet. That's what John Adams and some of the other men are doing in Paris now, talking over the peace terms."

"I hope they hurry up about it," Nat said.

Months went by, a year passed, and finally in the spring of '83, almost a year and a half after the fighting had stopped, General Washington proclaimed the peace.

Again Salem was the proudest town in the country. Salem's Captain John Derby brought news of the peace to America. He had been in Paris when the first terms of the peace treaty were settled.

"And he crowded sail," Father said, "and brought the news of the peace from Paris in twenty-two days! That takes nerve!"

Nat said, "Why does it take nerve to crowd sail?"

"The more sail you carry, the faster you go," Father told him. "But you have to watch out. If the wind rises suddenly, and blows hard against all that spread of sail, it can snap your masts."

"Was that how you lost the *Polly*?" Nat asked. "Were you crowding sail?"

Father shook his head. "No. A storm drove me on a lee shore, and I lost my anchor to windward." For a moment he was silent. "The windward side of a ship is the side the wind's coming from. The lee side is the other side of the ship. If a storm drives you toward land on your lee side, that's about the most dangerous thing that can happen to you. Your ship has to 'claw off' that lee shore — fight against the storm. If your ship can't claw off, then you'll heave an anchor to windward, to try to hold the ship where she is. That's your last chance to save her. If you lose your anchor to windward . . ." He stopped talking and sat a moment, staring at nothing. He sighed and stood. "Well, I'd better get back to making barrels." He left the house.

Lizza was big-eyed. "Wrecked on a reef!"

Lizza was big-eyed. "Wrecked on a reef!"

Nat said, "And that took the tuck out of Father, when he lost the *Polly*."

Granny bristled. "Who said so?"

"You did. I heard you tell Mother."

Granny eyed Nat over her spectacles. "Humph. Why don't you and Lizza go and watch the celebrating?"

They held hands and ran up Derby Street. Lizza gasped when the guns in Salem Harbor fired salutes and the cannon on the forts boomed an answer.

The sailors were celebrating louder than anyone else. One big sailor got up on a barrel and yelled questions. The others roared the answers.

“Who won this war?” he yelled.

“We did! The privateers of Salem!”

Lizza squeezed Nat’s hand. “Look! Captain Derby!”

Nat saw the tall, soldierly man crossing the street toward Derby Wharf. The sailor on the barrel saw him, too. He pointed.

“Who took the news of Lexington to England?”

The crowd yelled, “Captain John Derby!”

“Who brought the news of the peace to America?”

“Captain John Derby! Of Salem! Greatest city in America!”

Someone yelled, “New York’s the greatest! Salem’s next!”

A fight started. But Captain John Derby roared, “ ‘Vast there! To the Ship’s Tavern, and splice the main brace!”

The cheering, yelling men shoved each other and followed him to the tavern.

Lizza sighed. “Isn’t he wonderful, Nat? Isn’t everything wonderful? Now the war’s over and times will get better!”

But times didn't get better. Prices went right on climbing. When school was out, Nat helped his father in the cooperage. All summer he worked "from can-see to can't-see." Sometimes at night he was almost too tired to eat his supper. He was going to be glad, he thought, when school started again.

The night before school was to start, Father said, "You'll have to mind the shop tomorrow, Nat. I have to go over to Beverly."

Nat's stomach felt hollow. "But — but — school starts tomorrow."

"I know. But I need you, Nat."

"But — but — I thought — when school started again
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His father did not look at Nat. "Maybe, when times are better, you can go back. Right now, I need you." He picked up his hat. "I'll be back in a little while," he said.

No more school! Nat sat in a daze. The room swam in front of his eyes.

At nine o'clock, Father had not come back. Granny muttered under her breath and snapped at the children. At last everyone had gone to bed but Mother and Granny and Nat.

Mother said, "Nat, would you like to take a walk with me?"

Granny looked up sharply. "You've no business out in the night air."

Mother smiled. "Nonsense. I'm all right."

She and Nat went out into the dark, moonless night, and walked down Turner's Lane and out on the wharf. Mother helped Nat find the North Star, and told him how the Big Dipper swung around it, and how to tell time by the Dipper. Then she was silent, standing with her hand on Nat's shoulder, looking up at the stars.

Boys don't blubber. He must remember that. Finally Nat said, "It's all right about school, Mother. When times are better, I'll get to go back."

Mother did not answer. She was still gazing up at the sky. After a while she said, "I made up a sort of saying for myself, Nat. *I will lift up my eyes unto the stars.* Sometimes, if you look at the stars long enough, it helps. It shrinks your day-by-day troubles down to size." She smiled. "We'd better go back. Granny and Father will be wondering where we are."

When they got back to the house, Granny was still alone. She said, "Where'd you go?"

Mother said, "Nowhere. Just to look at the stars."

"You beat all." Granny shook her head. "I wonder where he is."

"He feels bad about keeping Nat out of school," Mother said.

Granny sighed. "Rum won't help. If he put more rum in barrels and less in . . ." She stopped. The wind began to rise. Granny shivered. "Going to be an early winter."